

C183 - Essay 1

Cartographic Interpretation

In this first *summative assessment*, you are being asked to deconstruct a map of your choice. You will be asked to critically analyze and evaluate different cartographic techniques, draw on secondary critical or historical literature about the map or the cartographic genre, and contextualize the map within its geography, history and authorship.

Format and Submission Guidelines

- ☐ Essays should be between **900 - 1,100 words** (+/-10%) in *argumentative length* (citation is excluded)
- ☐ **You must include:**
 - ☐ A **quote** from assigned course reading
 - ☐ A **key concept** and explanation of your analytic frame
 - ☐ **Details of the map**, including who/when/where/how
- ☐ Formatting
 - ☐ Use **12 point, Times New Roman** font with double spacing
 - ☐ **MLA style** for citations and bibliography
- ☐ Submit the documents as .pdf files on bCourses, using the following naming convention
“**LastName_Essay 1**”
 - ☐ **DATE: September 23rd, 11:59 PM**

Assessment Context

Throughout the semester, we are engaging with scholarship concerned with how maps create, shape and constrain our worlds. Maps emerge in specific encounters between image production and the people producing them, and they can have serious consequences. These encounters are messy and entangled in centuries of Cartographic endeavor, constructing documents that claim to know a place. Though a map tries to argue for a ‘world’, there is a world *within the map itself*: data classification systems, drafting techniques, visual design principles, political contexts, scientific methods and much more. As you read the article last week by Wilmott and Wood, you learned about the complex process of producing a single sheet of mylar for the Wood Street Commons (Built Environment students: the Assessor’s office will become a prominent figure for all urban development and architectural mapping projects). Any written account will never capture the complexity of a mapping project’s entanglements, but *writing through it* is how you start to build a habit of sustained reflection while making. Writing deepens your approach to practice.

Selecting a Map

Look for maps that suggest rhetorical effects (Edes Harrison World War 2 newspaper spectacles), or maps which appear benign but can be leveraged as a tool for political action (black and white land surveying plats). The maps you select should be consequential and communal— ones which generate public discourse about its meaning or shape action in the landscape. Choose a map you encounter in your daily life, or utilize one of the archival databases you found during your first worksheet assessment to retrieve one you find compelling.

Developing the Analysis

Your essay should provide an account of a particular map. The account should draw on historical literature about the map’s context, secondary/analytical sources about the techniques being used to produce the map and Cartographic theory/criticism to put the map into an intellectual conversation with the discipline.

Visual description should drive the deconstruction of the map. Observations about the map as an *image* will lead you to ask questions about the map as a *process*. When you start asking questions about the process, that is where the entanglement occurs with issues in cartographic representation.

Key questions you can ask about the process:

- ☐ What is the cultural and political **context** of the map?
- ☐ What **data** are included on the map? What do the **choices** reveal about the map and mapmaker? Does the information, given the context, accurately describe the actions in the landscape?
- ☐ What **methods** are used to produce the map?
- ☐ What **visual design techniques** does the cartographer employ to help represent and symbolize real features in the landscape?
- ☐ Considering the context, methods and design: what is the cartographer **rhetorically** communicating about geographic space? To **who** and **why**?

- ☐ What are the **implications** of the map? What work does the map do once it is in the view of the public? (Think about how Clancy and Alexis's map of Wood Street became a political subject in the eyes of the State Governor)
- ☐ Finally, does the map **unsettle an established idea** in the intellectual discipline of cartography? If so, how?

Brief Analysis Flow

I (Jack) will be working alongside you in some of the assignments this semester as they overlap with personal projects of mine. One of those is an analysis piece on the sidewalk maps I made for the Department of Public Works. The visual analysis is a sort of “first step” in thinking through my work and putting it into context to take on a new meaning.

Here is a flow of how I am approaching the outline (a piece that might be roughly 2000-3000 words):

1. **Context:** Who is making the maps? Under which circumstances? What is the history of this kind of map making technique? Providing a historical and situational context of the map absent of analysis.
 - a. Sources: primary archival documents, official documentation and procedure, secondary literature about the content being mapped.
2. **Analysis** - Visually describing the map as an image, and then thinking about the production techniques of the engineering drawing. This will lead me to question the process of the map.
 - a. Sources: an image of the map in question, secondary literature about the technique(s)
3. **Intervention** - Where does this map stand in the larger conversation of cartography? Is there an idea from a field of inquiry that the map is unsettling? Why? Can the maps I made contribute to the intellectual canon of thought in Cartography? If so, how?
 - a. Sources: direct quotes from a Cartographic theorist and/or another related field (i.e. in this case, an idea from social theory, rhetoric or city planning).
 - b. This would be the area of the paper where I put authors in direct conversation with each other to test the limits of or extend a preexisting theory. Similar to how a scientist uses lab experiments to test established laws in their discipline.

Rubric

	Critical	Analytical
Outstanding	Demonstrates outstanding use of cartographic practice to critically engage, deconstruct and critique cartographic concepts, including epistemology, ontology and power in a sophisticated, nuanced and persuasive manner	Demonstrates outstanding analytical and rhetorical structures, effectively using the capacities of cartography to produce persuasive argumentation in conversation with independent academic research.
Excellent	Demonstrates excellent use of cartographic research to critically engage, deconstruct and critique cartographic concepts, including independent research and reading	Demonstrates excellent and logical cartographic analysis, with strong conclusions supported by clear evidence, and excellent use of the rhetorical structures of cartography
Good	Demonstrates solid engagement with critical cartographic concepts, gleaned from course readings and assessments	Demonstrates good analysis either of or using cartographic rhetoric, with clear justification of decision making based in cartographic theory, framings or principles.
Basic	Demonstrates basic engagement with critical cartographic concepts, gleaned largely from lectures	Demonstrates some analytical framing, with limited engagement of cartographic and argumentation literature outside the course.
Needs Development	Demonstrates limited engagement with critical concepts	Demonstrates limited analysis, with little argumentative or rhetorical function.